



Realism is Bollywood's new buzzword. Global terror attacks, Mumbai blasts and satin-trimmed runways provide the new backdrops for supersize smash-ups and smouldering scenes.

among the big dramas and the bigger actioners are a series of films that look at life uncompromisingly. Films that take off where headlines end, that go beyond half-hour news channel specials. It's not surprising. Bollywood has tried almost every genre in recent times. Big budget no-brainers with bikini babes and dandy dudes with waxed chests have run their course. As have films which mine the funny vein—there are only so many bodily functions that one can joke about. Life in a metro is an attractive proposition, especially given the perils that accompany it.

For established filmmakers like Sanjay Leela Bhansali, it may have no



WEDNESDAY

Anupam Kher plays a police officer who suspects Naseeruddin Shah is behind the threat of bomb blasts. **THE INSPIRATION:** July 11, 2006 explosions in Mumbai.

romance. "When you've lived all your life in Bhendi Bazaar, there's no fun in taking a hand-held camera and walking through its streets," he said, explaining why he, having grown up in Mumbai's mean streets, made the neverland in *Saawariya*. But for a new generation of filmmakers with greater exposure to world cinema, there's a great urge to replicate global themes. As Apoorva Lakhia, director of the forthcoming *Mission Istaanbul*, says cynically, "In Bollywood if you copy from one DVD, it's a rip-off. If you copy from five, it's research." To a certain extent, he's right.

HIJACK

Shiney Ahuja, an airport maintenance engineer, has to save passengers on a plane hijacked by six terrorists who want the release of their leader. **THE INSPIRATION:** the IC-814 hijack.

New filmmakers are borrowing Western ways of story-telling to describe the Indian condition, which doesn't exist in songs shot in Switzerland, but in trains, planes and automobiles. So trains are blown up to serve as the backdrop for Mumbai's July 11, 2006, train blasts in Nishikant Kamat's *Bombay Meri Jaan* and a three-engine Tristar is set on fake fire at the Ras Al-khaimah airport near Dubai, where ad film director Kunal Shivdasani shot *Hijack*, based on the IC-814 hijack in 1999. And in the car-chase-studded *Mission Istaanbul*, a tape that shows the death of an Osama bin Laden lookalike, Abu Nazir, falls into the hands of an Indian journalist, who goes on the run with the help of a Turkish commando.

In Bollywood's time-honoured tradition, all the films are "different". But all the filmmakers are wary of straying too far afield, so every film is "filmi" enough to be commercial. So Zayed Khan is impeccably dressed in fedora and trenchcoat à la Humphrey Bogart in *Mission Istaanbul*, while Varma has kept his trademark item song in *Contract*, the third part of his examination of the underworld after *Satya* and *Company*. Seeing footage of real events intruding on the big screen is an experience the audience has to get used to, even in a made-for-children movie such as *Thoda Pyaar Thoda Magic*. In its few conces-

sions to reality, the film not only has a BMW-driving industrialist mow down a family, but also a tarot card reading futurologist named Sunita Menon, who's a personal goddess for society girls in search of the perfect Prada bag.

One of the leading exponents of the underbelly genre, Madhur Bhandarkar, is also reveling in the free-for-all likely to follow when he unveils some tit-tle-tattle in *Fashion*—from a Rohit Bal lookalike to Priyanka Chopra's character being partly based on trouble-prone models Shivani Kapur and Alecia Raut. News channels were the starting point for *Fashion* too. "I kept wondering if these channels are doing half-hour shows on the fashion weeks, there must be something there. I wanted to see their world with make-up and without